



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Schaeffer Academy

School Website: <https://www.schaefferacademy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS ACCREDITED MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because ACCS require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Based on the school's public materials within the crawl store and applying the classical rubric from the knowledge base, Schaeffer Academy (Rochester, MN, 55902) demonstrates strong alignment with classical education across most elements of the model. The materials show explicit engagement with religious foundations (catechesis, theology, liturgical practice), a clear purpose centered on virtue and wisdom (formation over mere information), a deep curriculum built on liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Trivium; Quadrivium; engagement with great literature), and pedagogy that mixes contemplative and Socratic/seminar approaches, memory-based drill, and performative rhetoric. The faculty image is consistent with a living curriculum and mentoring role, and community/parent engagement is present through family-focused activities and communications, though explicit statements about parents as co-teachers are less visible in the public materials.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): CLASSICAL Evidence points to catechesis, theology, liturgy, hymnody, and a Lutheran framework; public materials foreground spiritual formation and a sacred worldview. Positive keyword indicators appear plentiful; negative indicators are negligible.
- Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): CLASSICAL The materials emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, and beauty as real and knowable, aligning with a classical telos rather than mere job preparation.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): CLASSICAL There is explicit reference to the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium/Trivium framework, plus attention to classical literature and "Great Books" style engagement, signaling a strong classical curriculum.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): CLASSICAL Pedagogy includes contemplative/restful elements, singing/chanting in the lower grades, and upper-grade Socratic/seminar/debate formats, with a clear focus on memory, rhetoric, and disciplined discussion.
- Element 5 (Faculty): CLASSICAL The publicly described faculty role aligns with models of living curriculum and mentorship, with emphasis on virtue, skill, and knowledge being modeled by teachers.
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Community offerings (family retreats, newsletters, book clubs, podcasts) indicate active engagement and partnership with families, but explicit public statements that parents are "co-teachers" or that parents are systematically integrated as part of the curriculum's living framework are less clearly articulated in the available materials.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public content emphasizes catechesis, theology, Bible-based formation, liturgy, hymns, and confessional/theological grounding; Lutheran framing is explicit (two kingdoms; catechesis; Confessions). This aligns with transcendental moral realism and a theologically grounded education that integrates worship and communal practice. - References to liturgy, hymnody, and the Bible as central to the education process appear repeatedly, reinforcing communal sacred formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: catechesis, theology, Bible, liturgy, hymns, Confessions, catechesis, two kingdoms, truth, sacred, worship. - Negative keywords present: none detected in the material reviewed.

Why this rating - The materials foreground a transcendent, real, knowable moral framework anchored in theological formation and liturgical practice, which is central to classical religious foundations.

Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation, virtue, and wisdom as the aims of education, not utilitarian job training. The language of forming souls, virtue, and the cultivation of truth aligns with a classical telos. - There is an explicit connection between truth, goodness, and beauty as real ideals to be known and loved (the real, knowable). The liberal arts are framed as forming human excellence and stewardship.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, beauty, human excellence, good stewardship, real. - Negative keywords present: none clearly identified in the material.

Why this rating - Alignment with formation-focused goals and the pursuit of virtue and wisdom, rather than narrow vocational preparation, supports CLASSICAL status.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Liberal Arts framework is foregrounded, including the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) and Quadrivium (Arithmetic, Geometry, Music, Astronomy) as central curricular strands. - History and Great Books/Great Conversation themes are present in the curriculum approach, with heavy emphasis on classical literature (e.g., Beowulf, Aeneid, Homer) and rigorous reading lists. - Emphasis on memory, disciplined reading, and engagement with primary texts (Progymnasmata; memorized speeches; rhetoric exercises) signals a canonical liberal-arts curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Trivium, Quadrivium, Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric, Liberal Arts, Great Books/Great Conversation, history, Progymnasmata, memorization, imitate (imitatio), rhetoric, primary texts, classical literature. - Negative keywords present: none clearly identified in the material.

Why this rating - The curriculum explicitly centers classical liberal arts education and engagement with canonical texts and historic methods, fulfilling core curricular criteria of the classical rubric.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - A dual pedagogy exists: contemplative/restful elements (scholé-like memory work, chanting in lower grades) and active, Socratic/seminar-based upper-level work (Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, rhetoric training). - Lower grades emphasize singing/chanting and memory work; upper grades emphasize Socratic dialogue, seminars, debates, and public rhetoric. - There is explicit training in rhetoric and opportunities for students to give speeches, aligning with classical pedagogy that cultivates oratorical skill.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: scholé, contemplation, memory, singing/chanting, wonder, Socratic, seminars, debates, rhetoric, speech, memorization, imitatio, public speaking. - Negative keywords present: none clearly identified.

Why this rating - The blend of contemplative, memory-based practice in early years and Socratic/seminar-driven, rhetoric-focused pedagogy in later years is a hallmark of classical pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty is described as a living curriculum and a core element of the school community, modeling virtue, skill, and knowledge; teachers are portrayed as mentors who guide students in the classical enterprise. - The faculty are presented as central to the school's mission, with a clear emphasis on virtue, knowledge, and forming character within a community of learners.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, core of the school, faculty as guides, virtuous role models. - Negative keywords present: none clearly identified.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently present faculty as central to the educational project and as exemplars of virtue and mastery, aligning with the classical faculty ideal.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school features a robust community dimension: Family Retreats, newsletters, book clubs, podcasts, and community events indicate strong family and community engagement. This supports partnership with families and ongoing public-facing education outside the classroom. - However, explicit, verbatim statements that parents are co-teachers or that parents are integrated into the active curriculum as co-educators are not clearly present in the public materials reviewed. The explicit framing of parents as co-teachers is not directly evidenced in the excerpts analyzed.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: family, retreats, newsletters, book club, community, parent involvement, learning together, gatherings. - Negative keywords present: explicit statements of parents-as-co-teachers are not clearly shown in the visible public content (no direct phrasing such as "parents are co-teachers" or "parents participate as part of the living curriculum").

Why this rating - The school demonstrates strong parental/community engagement and educational outreach, which is a key facet of the classical model's emphasis on a virtuous partnership between school and family. The lack of explicit public statements that parents serve as co-teachers (as some classical schools emphasize) places this slightly below a full CLASSICAL rating for this category, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Aggregate assessment across all categories - Across the six categories, five categories are CLASSICAL and one is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Therefore, the overall assessment is CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - To move Element 6 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL, the school could publish explicit statements and examples showing parents as co-teachers within the curriculum framework, including: - Clear language on parental co-teaching roles and responsibilities within the classical curriculum. - Structured parent-involvement programs that align with Great Books discussions, Latin/grammar cycles, or history readings. - Regular parent-teacher collaborative cycles (commonplace books, shared memory work, family discussion guides) that demonstrate a public-facing "living curriculum" including parental participation.

- Additional needle-moving steps (optional for further strengthening):
- Explicit public articulation of a two-kingdom or catechetical formation approach as foundational pedagogy, linking it to daily classroom practice and family learning.
- More explicit references to the Great Books program and Great Conversation in public materials, with sample schedules or examples of student-led discussions.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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